

JANUARY 16-31, 1979

December 15). A lot needs to be done to curb terrorism and save hapless citizens from falling prey to it over and over again.

NARENDRA SHAH, *Mumbai*,
via www.indiatoday.in

Mandal Messiah

The zeal and passion with which former prime minister V.P. Singh led the country during troubled times will be remembered always ('Obituary', December 15). The manner in which he "formed" and "gave up" his government is a lesson for our pseudo-secularists and opportunist politicians. Singh never succumbed to forces and pressures that he believed were jeopardising the secularism of India. His secular credentials were proved beyond doubt when he ordered the arrest of L.K. Advani during his historic *rath yatra* in an effort to save Babri mosque and thereby the secular and democratic fabric of the nation.

KHAN YASIR,
via www.indiatoday.in

Crisis Group

Your news article ("Lessons from Mumbai", December 15) said: "In theory, the crisis management group headed by the chief secretary and its members should have met within an hour. In Mumbai the chief secretary was at home, the crisis room was manned by the DGP, Patil and senior officers and

Home Secretary Chitkala Zutshi were among those trapped at the Sea Lounge in the Taj and calling for help." In this context I wish to clarify as under: On November 26, 2008, when the city of Mumbai suffered terrorist attacks, I reached my Mantralaya office sometime around 9.45 pm, within half-an-hour of the first reported terrorist firing in Colaba area, and mobilised the Crisis Management Team by calling secretaries concerned. In fact, some of the secretaries had al-

ready reached Mantralaya from Mantralaya without any break, with the involvement of all the agencies.

JOHNY JOSEPH,
Chief Secretary,
Government of Maharashtra

Our information was based on inputs received from the then deputy chief minister in charge of home and other senior officials who were with him at the DGP Headquarters. The fact that the chief secretary and other secretaries worked nonstop to man relief and other services is not in dispute. What is be-



HEMANT CHAWLA

Sheila Dikshit's hat-trick was surprising. Her opponent V.K. Malhotra was no match for her clean image and her development initiatives for the welfare of Delhiites.

RATAN SHARGA, via www.indiatoday.in

ready reached Mantralaya on their own on getting information of the attacks from electronic media. I would like to mention here that throughout the duration of the operation of 59 hours, the crisis management group consisting of myself along with supporting team, co-ordinated all activities

ing stated is that the first hour response that is so critical was not coherent.
EDITOR

Corrigendum

The news item ("Home Match", December 22) erroneously mentioned that O.P. Babbar will serve his eighth term as MLA. It will be his third.

Bright Ray

As a child, Satyajit Ray, the world famous filmmaker, never once thought that he would make films. He grew up in his ancestral mansion in Calcutta, drawing and painting. He would doodle the long summer afternoons away hoping that his attempted portraits and cartoons would appear in his family's famous children's magazine *Sandesh*. As a Brahmin, his family regarded the cinema and theatre as frivolities. His first boyhood wonder was his father's printing press. He remembers having been lifted up to look through the ground-glass view finder of the tall halftone camera. He often visited Shantiniketan where he played with Rabindranath Tagore's grand-daughter. He has fond memories of the florist's shop in New Market and stately horse-drawn carriages giving way to automobiles. As a child, all he wanted when he grew up was to be a painter.



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